

PBS Authority for testosterone in gender-affirming care: how it is worded

A one-page card for prescribers and pharmacists · gamsa.au/clinicians

The situation

There is no PBS listing for gender affirmation. Every PBS testosterone item is listed for androgen deficiency and needs an Authority prescription. Written as a private script, the same product can cost well over a hundred dollars instead of a co-payment, so the paperwork is the single biggest lever on what the patient pays.

Who can prescribe on the PBS

The restriction requires that the patient is treated by, in consultation with, or waiting on an appointment with a specialist: endocrinologist, paediatric endocrinologist, urologist, paediatrician, or a sexual health physician (Fellow of the Australasian Chapter of Sexual Health Medicine). The specialist's name goes on the Authority application. Once that is in place, a GP or nurse practitioner can write the PBS script.

The indication used

The Australian position statement tells prescribers to apply under **"androgen deficiency due to an established testicular disorder"**, with prescribing by or in consultation with a paediatrician, endocrinologist, urologist or sexual health physician whose name appears on the application.

The PBS item pages publish only the indication headings (androgen deficiency, micropenis, pubertal induction, constitutional delay); read the current restriction from the PBS Schedule or the Authority line at the time of prescribing.

Before the patient reaches the counter

- ☐ Specialist consultation or pending appointment documented, name recorded
- ☐ Authority obtained (online or phone) and number on the script
- ☐ Formulation and strength match the PBS item (long-acting injection, gel, or short-acting injection)
- ☐ Patient told the script is PBS Authority, and what the wording will say

What the wording means, and does not mean

Read plainly, the indication describes testes that do not produce testosterone because of disease or damage. It is a listing written long before gender-affirming care was considered and never rewritten. It does not mean the prescription is wrong, that the prescriber has invented anything, or that the patient's entitlement or price is different.

A line to use at the counter

"The PBS has no listing written for gender-affirming care, so testosterone is subsidised under its androgen deficiency indication. The wording is a funding category, not a description of you. Your price and your entitlement are the same as for anyone on a PBS Authority script."

Other hormone medicines

Estradiol, spironolactone and cyproterone are General Schedule items and need no Authority. Estradiol patches are often in short supply; check gamsa.au/supply before telling a patient a product is unavailable.

Sources: Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme item listings for testosterone products (pbs.gov.au); Cheung AS et al. Position statement on the hormonal management of adult transgender and gender diverse individuals. *Med J Aust* 2019;211:127–133. Patient explanation and references: gamsa.au/costs. Not medical advice; the PBS Schedule in force on the day governs.



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